

Painting before you list

Most sellers either paint everything or paint nothing. Both cost more than they need to. Here is where paint actually changes a buyer's mind — and where it doesn't.

A buyer walks a fixed path: kerb, front door, entry, main living, kitchen, then bedrooms. By the fourth bedroom they have formed a view and are looking for confirmation of it. Paint spent early on that path is worth more than the same paint spent late.

WORTH DOING

● Front door and entry

The one surface every buyer touches, at the moment they decide what kind of property this is.

● Main living and hallway walls

The most visible wear in an occupied home, and the backdrop to most of the photography.

● Ceilings with water or smoke marks

Buyers read staining as an unresolved problem, not a cosmetic one — and it follows them into the negotiation.

● Trim and skirting in high-traffic areas

Scuffed trim stands out more once the walls around it are fresh, not less.

USUALLY SKIP

— Inside wardrobes and cupboards

Opened, glanced at, closed. None of it reaches a photo.

— Garage and laundry

Behind the machines and behind the roller door, nobody is forming a view.

— An exterior that is genuinely sound

Intact coating with no chalking or flaking? A wash presents it honestly. Bare timber or failing paint is a different decision.

— Neutral secondary bedrooms

Sound walls in a broad-appeal colour return close to nothing repainted.

The most common mistake: touching up with the old tin

Paint on a wall ages. Leftover paint from the original tin will not match the surface around it, and a sheen difference catches the light from across the room. Under listing photography that patch reads as clearly as the mark it was meant to hide — and to a buyer it reads as corners cut, not as a small repair. Where a wall has visible marks, repaint the full wall corner to corner.

SEQUENCING A CAMPAIGN

Paint first

Painting is the first trade on site, never the last. Working around staged furniture is slower, riskier for the stylist's pieces, and harder to finish cleanly into corners.

Work back from photography

The property needs to be painted, dry and properly ventilated with days to spare — not finished the night before the shoot.

Settle colour before the quote

Warm whites and broad-appeal neutrals. Every personal choice a buyer has to mentally undo is one more reason they picture someone else's home.